Scripted

By Mark Harvey Levine

A comfy, lived-in bedroom. SIMON and ELAINE asleep. The alarm goes off.

ELAINE: **(Pg 67+)** Oh, God, don't make me get up. . . *(Simon reaches over to turn off the alarm. His hand rests on a script. He picks it up.)* What time is it? *(Simon is engrossed in the script.)* Simon? What time is it?

SIMON: *(reading from the script)* "It's. . . 7:20. . . "

ELAINE: You didn't even look at the clock. . . *(Simon looks at the clock.)*

SIMON: It IS 7:20. . . *(Simon looks back at the script - reading)* "It IS 7:20. . . "

ELAINE: Whatcha got?

SIMON: This isn't yours?

ELAINE: No. . .

SIMON: I found it. . . on the nightstand. . .

ELAINE: What is it?

SIMON: It's. . . a. . . script. . .

ELAINE: You mean like for a movie?

SIMON: No. . . For us. It's us. It's-- This is what's happening right now.

ELAINE: What? What are you talking about. . . ?

SIMON: Say something. Say anything.

ELAINE AND SIMON: *(simultaneously)* The cows are barking at midnight! How did you do that? Stop that! STOP IT!!

ELAINE: Simon, my God how are you doing this?

SIMON: I don't know! I don't know! I just found this script. Our script. This is-- I know everything you're about to say.

ELAINE: What do you mean?! What do you mean?!

SIMON: Look! Read it!

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ELAINE: Oh my God. . . it knows what I'm going to say. . . what I'm saying. . . right now. . . Aaugh! *(She drops the script. He picks it up.)*

SIMON: And we can't seem to help saying. . . *(turns page)* . . . what we're supposed to say.

ELAINE: Well. . . just don't. Say something different. Look at your next line, and say something else. Anything else. . .

SIMON: *(struggling)* I. . . can't. . . *(Elaine grabs the script.)*

ELAINE: *(reading)* "I can't." *(panicking)* Okay. Okay. Okay.

SIMON: All right, let's not panic.

ELAINE: I'm not panicking. . .

SIMON: Yes you are -- it says so, in parentheses. . . "Elaine. . . panicking. . . "

ELAINE: Don't look at it! Just don't look! Put it down! Put it down! *(She throws the script to the floor. They cross as far away from it as they can, clutching each other.)*

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Do you keep experiencing the same situations over and over again?*
ACTRESS: *Do you keep wishing things would turn out differently; only to have it end up the same way time and again?*
ACTOR: *Despite your best efforts, does it always seems to be the same old story?*
ACTRESS: *Even if we recognize it or not, our lives are compelled by a story; it follows a script that we have either written for ourselves or it has been written for us by others.*
ACTOR: *Are you a hero or a victim, or lesser, just an extra scene – lost in the mass? Whatever you might be, you need to realize you are the central character of your life story.*
ACTRESS: *And you have the power to change it!*
TOGETHER: *Scripted by Mark Harvey Levine*

SIMON: All right. . . let's stay calm. . . let's try to think here. . .

ELAINE: How can we stay calm?! Simon, we've got our lives. . . our own words written down and plonked on our nightstand!

SIMON: It wasn't there last night. . .

ELAINE: So who put it here? Who wrote this? Someone came in while we were asleep? Into our apartment?

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SIMON: How could anyone know what we're going to say? Elaine, I think. . . someone. . . is trying to tell us something. . .

ELAINE: Someone?

SIMON: Y'know. . . God. . .

ELAINE: No! No No No! Stop that! I don't want God to tell me things! The God I believe in does NOT drop off scripts in the middle of the night!

SIMON: Maybe it's a warning! Maybe something horrible happens today. . . and we have a chance to prevent it. . .

ELAINE: You think?

SIMON: We have to see.

ELAINE: Okay, but don't let go of me. *(Together, they shuffle over to the script. Simon gingerly picks it up. Pause. Dramatically, he opens it.)* AAAAAUGH! *(Simon drops it as if it were alive.)* Sorry. Sorry. I'm just scared. Go ahead, I'm not even gonna look. *(He picks the script up again. Elaine looks away. He starts to read.)*

SIMON: Okay. . . okay. Let's see. Well, I'm going to be late for work. Probably 'cause I'm standing here reading this thing. *(flips ahead more)* You sing show tunes while you grade papers?

ELAINE: Only when I'm upset. You don't find this horribly frightening?

SIMON: No. . . I mean, yes, but. . . I think it's kinda neat. . . *(reads further)* Your mom's gonna call.

ELAINE: Oh, great. *(She looks at the script.)* My God. . . our whole conversation is in here. This is so embarrassing. Look —- it takes us three pages to get off the phone. *(reading both parts)* "All right. . . " "Okay. . . " "I'll talk to you later. . . " "All right. . . " "So everything's okay?" "Everything's okay." "All right. . . " "Okay. . . " God! We sound so stupid all written down like this.

SIMON: Look at me, I never finish a sentence. All my lines end in "dot, dot, dot". . .

ELAINE: Simon. . . I'm scared--

SIMON: I know, sweetie. . .

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ELAINE: No, I mean, what if. . . what if one of us. . . dies. . . in this? What if that's why this is here?

SIMON: Well, then,. . . we'll just avoid whatever it is. I mean, y'know, if it's a car wreck or something, then we'll just stay inside. . .

ELAINE: That never works. You've watched the Twilight Zone. Y'know, the car crashes through the house anyway.

SIMON: Well, then, lemme look at the end. Let's see how this thing ends.

ELAINE: Oh God. Okay.

SIMON: I mean, we have to know. . .

ELAINE: Okay. *(Terrified, he turns to the last page. They both exhale in relief.)*

SIMON: We're alive.

ELAINE: We just say goodnight and go to bed. That's nice. . .

SIMON: It looks like our whole day is here. . .

ELAINE: Okay, then. Let's read it from the beginning. I want to know what happens.

SIMON: Are you sure?

ELAINE: Yeah. . . Yes.

SIMON: Okay. . . here we go. . . *(He flips back to the beginning. They begin to read. The lights change a few times to denote passage of time. They finish reading.)*

ELAINE: The end.

SIMON: That's it?

ELAINE: That's it.

SIMON: Nothing happened.

ELAINE: Thank God.

SIMON: I mean. . . NOTHING happened. . .

ELAINE: I was so terrified something horrible was-- I mean, even if nobody died, we could have-

SIMON: It's kind of cool. . . to see what it looks like, the way we talk, and. . . but. . . y'know something? That was the most boring thing I've ever read.

ELAINE: I know, and I'm thrilled. I've had enough excitement for one day.

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SIMON: So why is this here? Why did we get this script? What's the -- y'know, "Why is this day different from all other days?" And. . . it's not. It's just another completely interchangeable day.

ELAINE: Simon, what do you want? Car chases? Shootouts? We're real people. Perfectly wonderfully boringly normal. I have to go to the bathroom. *(Elaine exits to the bathroom.)*

SIMON: Yeah, that's it. We go to the bathroom, we watch a little TV, and the next thing you know you're sixty-five years old.

ELAINE: *(Off-stage)* Oh, God.

SIMON: I mean. . . I got so excited when we found this, y'know? I was terrified. . . but I thought-- Wow! SOMETHING incredible must happen today! And we've been warned because. . . I don't know, because we're special or something.

ELAINE: *(O.S., brushing her teeth)* Well, at least we know what our day's going to be like.

SIMON: What, that I go to work and make labels for the archive while you stay at home and grade papers?

ELAINE: *(O.S., still brushing)* Well-- *(spits)* Yeah. *(spits)*

SIMON: We don't need a script for that! I could've told you that yesterday! I could've told you that three days ago! I mean, if you'd like, I can write out all of next week for you. . . *(Elaine reenters. Pause.)*

ELAINE: Are we that predictable? *(Simon waves the script at her.)* Oh, right.

SIMON: I mean, really. Why NOT drop the script off first thing in the morning. We don't DO anything. This way, we can just read our whole day and go right back to bed.

ELAINE: . . . Wanna rob a bank?

SIMON: You know what I mean. I mean, I just saw my entire day, and I want my money back.

ELAINE: Every day can't be a wild adventure, Simon. NOBODY lives like that. That's the movies, that's TV. There's nothing wrong with going to work, earning your pay, coming home to your sweetie who, by the way, loves you, going to bed and saying good night. The end. I like that day. That's a good day.

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SIMON: Would you pay to go see it?

ELAINE: Maybe not but I'm thrilled to live it.

SIMON: I'm not. Elaine. . . it's like. . . Do you know who my Great Grandfather was?

ELAINE: No.

SIMON: . . . Neither do I. I'm only three generations away and he's completely VANISHED. He didn't leave a trace. I don't want to vanish when the curtain closes. I don't want to just have a nice normal boring life until one day I'm gone and the next day my Great Grandson doesn't even know what my name was.

ELAINE: Nobody gets remembered forever. Except for, y'know, Lincoln. And Kennedy. Maybe you can get assassinated.

SIMON: I just want to. . . I want them to remember me, and say "He was great".

ELAINE: Y'know, I think this is a generational thing. Our parents were quite happy to get married and have children and homes and jobs and that was it. It's only our generation where you have to win a Pulitzer or you've failed.

SIMON: Yeah, well, they did this to us.

ELAINE: I don't feel like I have to be "great". I just want to have a great life, y'know?

SIMON: Well, you've read this thing. Was it great?

ELAINE: Every DAY doesn't have to be whiz-bang to make a -- Wait, do you remember mentioning your Great Grandfather?

SIMON: Just now?

ELAINE: No, in the script. You didn't bring him up in the script, did you?

SIMON: No. . . No!

ELAINE: You changed your line.

SIMON: I changed my line. *(laughs)* I changed my line!

ELAINE: Look in the script. *(Simon finds the appropriate section. He screams in horror.)* What?

SIMON: *(He shows her)* A pink replacement page!

ELAINE: My God.

SIMON: But we can change it. We CAN change it.

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ELAINE: So. . . let's change it. What do you want to do?

SIMON: I don't know. I just want to do something. Y'know? So that if anyone DOES remember us, they'll say we were. . .

ELAINE: A real couple of characters?

SIMON: Yeah! Right.

ELAINE: So, what, we're going to totally change our lives? Quit our jobs, move to Peru and become goat farmers?

SIMON: I don't think that would be terribly fulfilling. No, y'know what I want? I want a pink replacement page, at least one, every day. Every day we have to do at least one completely unexpected. . . crazy. . . memorable . . . thing.

ELAINE: Okay, well, let's start right now. Gimme a pen. (She grabs one from a nightstand.)

SIMON: What are you doing?

ELAINE: A little rewriting.

SIMON: *(peering over her shoulder)* Goodness!. . . Well, now we know why I'm going to be late for work. . .

ELAINE: *(writes a little more)* What do you think?

SIMON: I think. . . I think you write really good stage directions. I think. . . I'm going to remember today.

ELAINE: *(As she writes the final sentence)* They. . . kiss. Lights. . . out. *(They kiss.)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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